



The Freenet Project

What is it?

The Freenet Project aims to create a fully decentralised, free (as in Free Speech) Internet, where users can upload and access data anonymously, without persecution from the current Internet's Powers That Be—ICANN, for example.

Whose bright idea was that?

Ian Clarke, founder and CEO of thoof.com (which is a bit like Digg, but customisable) came up with the concept in his paper called *A Distributed Decentralised Information Storage and Retrieval System*, eventually leading to the creation of the project itself.

How does it work?

Think BitTorrent for Web sites—you install the Freenet client, and reserve some disk space for the project. That space will then be used to store Web pages, creating a huge storage grid that spans all Freenet's users. An entire site is encrypted and may be spread across as many as a hundred PCs (unlike on a single server now), so anyone with an intention to shut your site down has to hunt down just the right fragments of the site to do so—theoretically impossible.

Why does this tempt us so?

Think about it—an uncensored Internet opens up a whole new world of possibilities. Chinese users are using it to talk about politics without the fear of being clapped in irons, for example. All otherwise censored information is fair play in Freenet (yes, even the kind that just occurred to you).

Will this replace the Internet?

It won't, really. It's more like an underground Net hiding inside the bigger Internet. Besides, it wouldn't work without the infrastructure of the Internet.

Where do I sign up?

Visit <http://freenetproject.org> for more information on the project and to download the client.

access to the Internet. There need to be paying customers before infrastructure is laid out—and poverty is so widespread that it becomes a hurdle.

The Millennium Villages programme is but one step in aiding the continent's progress; it's a long road ahead.

BADDIES AHEAD

Unsafer And Unsafer

In a now-much-publicised statement, new McAfee CEO David DeWalt says cyber-crime has become a \$105 billion business, a figure that surpasses the corresponding figure for the illegal drug trade worldwide.

The capacity of law enforcement agencies to find and prosecute cyber-criminals has just not kept up with the pace at which they're evolving. (Read: the criminals are ahead of the rest of us.) As DeWalt so nicely put it, "If you rob a 7-11 you'll get a much harsher punishment than if you stole millions online." (7-11 is a chain of convenience stores.)

Then, speaking to the media in Malaysia at the Hack in the Box Security Conference in September, Lance Spitzner, president of the Honeynet Project, said writers of malicious software have been producing increasingly sophisticated codes with the motivation being money.

In the 1990s or so, security threats were motivated more by the desire for fame (as in notoriety) rather than for profit. It was a "fun" thing: those who carried out exploits for the money of it were looked down upon by the hacker community. But

all good things come to an end; it all comes down to the lowest common denominator. It's now organised crime much more than it is about thrills.

Spitzner should know, being president of the Honeynet Project: it is an organisation dedicated to improving the cause of Internet security, employing a network of "honeypots"—decoy servers that lure hackers so as to study their techniques.

Now here's the worrying part: Spitzner says the techniques used by criminal hackers are changing so



rapidly that it's difficult to keep up with them. "In the past 18 months, what has astounded me is not how sophisticated the tools are but how fast they have adapted and changed."

"Banking Trojans," for instance, are the latest avatars of malicious software designed to steal data. Mikko Hypponen, chief research officer at F-Secure, says there is currently no security tool to effectively protect against Banking Trojan exploits.

Essentially, Banking Trojans work in such a way that everything in the transaction seems OK both to the bank and to the customer—it's not like phishing, where users actually deliver information

to the wrong party.

We perhaps don't need to tell you that prevention is the best policy: that one needs to stay away from Web sites that May Harm Your Computer (and Google is increasingly coming to the rescue here), from opening suspicious e-mail attachments, download the latest patches for anti-spyware, anti-virus, and browser...

That's all fine, but will "anti-ware" itself be able to keep pace?

Here in India, hardly as many banking and other financial transactions are done online than in the Western countries, and so, there isn't as much sensitive data on people's computers. But on the other hand, cyber-crime laws aren't half as articulated as they are in the US and other countries. Besides, there's also the fact that more and more people are going to begin transacting online in the next few years. We're getting there.

Experts have been saying all along that the security situation could get worse. So much of our lives—even here in India, at least in the urban areas—are now dependant on bytes streaming from server to faceless server. All those bytes mean money, and few know the workings. It's the proverbial recipe for disaster.

Then, there is still the notion in people's minds that cyber-criminals have only tapped keys; that they haven't done a "real" crime. Those of us who get online often enough know that life in cyberspace isn't really "virtual"—and would tend to think of a cyber-criminal as any other criminal. And part of the problem could just be that those in charge of hunting down the bad guys don't get online often enough... Apart from "apply the latest patches and updates," there's really no conclusion to this one. ☒